

Training Academy: Curriculum and Badge Program

Oct 9, 2026 · @Kamil Salameh

Summary

The Training Academy turns the badge competency matrix into a training program. It onboards every new hire, runs the quarterly test windows and the semiannual KPI review, moves current staff into the new levels between January and March 2027, and runs the committee that awards badges and recommends promotions. One manager owns it, preferably the new Senior Manager. A committee of 2–3 managers, L4 Senior Specialists II, L3 Senior Specialists I and 2 rotating team leads runs it with the QA department. Levels, test windows, badge-loss rules and the transition are set in the Badges, Levels and Transition appendix.

What the Academy delivers:

- **Onboarding:** 2 weeks for new hires, in monthly cohorts of 4–6, so each hire is on track for L2 at 6 months.
- **Badge courses:** 9 courses, 5 core (C1–C5) and 4 advanced (A1–A4), each ending in supervised production and an assessment.
- **Quarterly test windows:** four a year, where members earn badges by course or by testing out on work they already do.
- **Semiannual KPI review:** every June 30 and December 31; members who lose 25% of their badges go on probation and coaching, and 50% leads to termination (from December 2027).
- **Transition, January–March 2027:** top 10% of each role earn their role badges automatically, the middle 80% have 3 months of tests, and the bottom 10% restart at L1 in the Academy.
- **Cross-training and leadership:** everyone holds the 5 core badges by June 30, 2027; a leadership track prepares future team leads and managers (L5).
- **Reporting:** a monthly team badge grid and Academy report to the leadership board.

Training happens mostly on live work. About 20% of each badge is classroom time and 80% is supervised production, checked by a badge-holder.

Governance: the Academy Committee

The Academy Committee owns training, badge awards and promotion recommendations. One manager chairs and owns it, and no member ever decides alone on their own team.

Seat	Who	Number	Term	Role on the committee
Chair (Academy owner)	A manager, preferably the Senior Manager (L5)	1	Standing	Owens the curriculum, calendar, test windows and semiannual review; confirms badge awards; chairs the promotion panel; reports monthly
Manager members	Team managers from different teams	2-3	12 months, staggered so one changes every 6 months	Calibrate placements and promotions; each sponsors 2-3 badge courses
L4 Senior Specialists II	Holders of the advanced badges they teach	2	12 months	Lead trainers and assessors for advanced badges
L3 Senior Specialists I	Strong core-badge holders	2	6 months	Trainers and assessors for core badges; buddies for new hires
Team leads	Rotating through all team leads	2	1 quarter	Bring floor feedback; run supervised production in their teams; join coaching assessments
QA reviewer	The existing QA department	1	Standing	QA scores, rulings on critical errors, a seat on every Badge Panel

Team lead rotation: 2 team leads join each quarter, so 8 team leads serve each year and every team lead serves about once every 18 months.

What the committee owns:

- The curriculum, course materials and the yearly training calendar.
- New-hire onboarding and each hire's 6-month plan to L2.
- The four quarterly test windows and the full skill assessment.
- The semiannual KPI review, badge losses, probation plans and termination recommendations.
- The January–March 2027 transition: the top and bottom 10% lists, the tests and the April 1 levels.
- The pool of trainers and assessors, and their quarterly calibration.
- Badge awards, suspensions and reinstatements; quarterly promotions for L1 to L4; shortlists for L5 team lead and manager posts.
- The monthly team badge grid, training priorities for teams with gaps, and appeals.

Decision rules:

- **Quorum:** the chair, 1 manager member, the QA reviewer and 2 other members.
- **Badges:** in each test window a Badge Panel scores the assessments: the QA reviewer plus 2 assessors from other teams. The chair confirms the award, and ClickUp routing switches on after any required supervised cases.
- **Badge loss:** the committee confirms the semiannual results. Probation is decided by the team manager and the chair; termination is recommended to the director and goes through HR.
- **Promotions (L1–L4):** the chair and 2 managers from outside the person's team confirm each case.
- **Team lead and manager posts (L5):** the committee shortlists from internal applicants, and the director and assistant directors approve.
- **Conflicts of interest:** members step out of any decision on their own team or direct reports.
- **Appeals:** one per decision, heard within 10 business days by members who did not make the original decision.

Learning paths

A new hire reaches L2 in about 6 months by earning the 5 core badges in a set order. Advanced badges then lead to L3 and L4. The order follows each badge's prerequisites, so no one starts a course they can't finish.

Stage	Badges earned, in order	Typical time	Exit criteria
Onboarding	Orientation, systems, NSA basics; starts C1 and C4	Weeks 1-2	Passes the onboarding written and practical checks
L1 RCM Specialist I	C1 and C4 (months 1-2), C5 (month 3), C2 (months 4-5), C3 (month 6)	6 months	All 5 core badges; work units at 100% of target; QA at or above 95%
L2 RCM Specialist II	2 advanced badges from A1, A2 and A3	At least 12 months	Net Recovery in the top 40% of the tier; QA at or above 97%
L3 Senior Specialist I	A2 and A4, plus A1 or A3; trainer certification	At least 18 months	Net Recovery in the top 20%; teaches at least one Academy module
L4 Senior Specialist II	Leads a specialty group; Academy trainer and assessor	Ongoing	Keeps all its badges at the semiannual review
L5 Principal (Leadership)	Team lead or manager posts only	By application	Coaching assessment (team lead) or leadership training (manager)

Leadership ladder (L5): an L3 or L4 can apply for team lead after the Team Lead readiness course and a coaching assessment. A team lead with 12 months in the role, or an L4, can apply for manager after the Manager readiness course.

Current staff (January–March 2027): current staff do not follow this order. They start at the default level for their role and move through the transition (see Rollout). Missing core badges are then earned through cross-training by June 30, 2027.

New-hire onboarding

New hires start in monthly cohorts of 4–6, on the first Monday of the month. They spend 2 weeks in the Academy and then join a team for supervised work. Each hire gets an L3 buddy from the committee's trainer pool and a written 6-month plan to L2.

Day	Topic	Format	Check
1	Welcome; the ER out-of-network revenue cycle end to end; HIPAA, PHI and security rules; approved use of AI tools	Classroom	HIPAA quiz, 100% required
2	Systems: eCW, ClickUp (Today list, statuses, routing), patient hub, payer portals	Hands-on lab	Navigation task in each system
3	No Surprises Act basics: emergency services, out of network, QPA, Open Negotiation, IDR timeline; NNSA and state-regulated plans	Classroom and scenarios	20-question quiz, 85% or higher
4	C1 module, part 1: claim lifecycle, mailing log, receipt confirmation, payer portals	Classroom; shadow a C1 holder	Logging exercise
5	C1 module, part 2: payer call script, reference numbers, next-action dates; week 1 review	Recorded call review; role-play	Mock call scored with the C1 checklist
6	C4 module, part 1: ERA and EOB reading, adjustment codes, exception queue	Classroom and lab	Read 10 EOBs
7	C4 module, part 2: manual posting, IDR award payments, refunds, batch balancing	Lab on training data	Balance a 15-item batch

Day	Topic	Format	Check
8	Documentation: reading an ER chart, E/M levels (99281–99285) at a glance, the medical-necessity report and approved prompts	Classroom	Chart-reading exercise
9	Deadlines and quality: the deadline board, QA checklists, critical errors, escalation; the US desk ticket flow	Classroom; visit QA	Critical-error quiz
10	Final checks; meet the team; buddy assigned; supervised production plan agreed	Assessment and team handover	Written test (80% or higher) and practical task

After the 2 weeks:

- **Weeks 3–8:** supervised production for C1 and C4 in the team, with every case signed off by a badge-holder in ClickUp.
- **Day 30, 60 and 90:** check-ins with the buddy and team lead. Day 90 confirms that the L1 targets are met: work units at target and QA at or above 90%.
- **Months 3–6:** C5, C2 and C3 courses in the Academy calendar, then L2 review at the next quarterly promotion window.

A hire who fails a day-10 check repeats that module with the next cohort. Two failed checks lead to a review by the chair and the hiring manager.

Core badge curriculum

The 5 core badges take 46 classroom hours in total, plus supervised production on live work. Every course follows the same four steps: Academy module, supervised production, Badge Panel assessment, award. The case counts and pass marks below come from the badge competency matrix.

Badge	Prerequisite	Classroom	Supervised production	Assessment	QA to earn	Usual trainer
C1 Claim Follow-up	None	8 hours	40 claims, 5+ payers	Live check of 10 claims; 3 recorded calls	95%	L3 C1 holder

Badge	Prerequisite	Classroom	Supervised production	Assessment	QA to earn	Usual trainer
C2 Open Negotiation	C1	12 hours	30 notices, 10 negotiations	20-scenario test (90%); 1 notice; 1 role-play	98%	L4 with A2 or A4
C3 NNSA Appeal	C1	10 hours	25 appeals, 2+ types	2 appeals written from case files	95%	L3 C3 holder
C4 Payment Posting	None	8 hours	100 postings, incl. 20 manual and 10 IDR awards	30-item batch that balances exactly	99%	L3 C4 holder
C5 Medical-Necessity Report	None	8 hours	30 reports	5 charts, zero factual errors	97%	L3 or A1 holder

C1. Claim Follow-up and Receipt Confirmation

1. Claim lifecycle and the mailing log; confirming receipt within 21 days (2 hours).
2. Payer portals and claim status codes (2 hours).
3. The payer call script, reference numbers and review of recorded calls (2 hours).
4. ClickUp statuses, next-action dates and resubmission requests to Logistics (2 hours).

C2. Open Negotiation (OMB)

1. NSA eligibility: emergency service, out of network, plan type, date of initial payment or denial (3 hours).
2. The QPA and the Open Negotiation notice: claim items, proof of delivery, the 30-business-day window (3 hours).
3. The pricing guide, decision rights and counter-offers (3 hours).
4. Negotiation practice: role-plays on common payer positions (3 hours).

C3. NNSA Appeal

1. NNSA process maps and state-regulated plans (2 hours).
2. Code appeals and money appeals; each payer's appeal limits (2 hours).
3. The appeal letter library and citing the medical-necessity report (3 hours).
4. Non-NSA denials, the 12-month closing rule and the high-dollar final review (3 hours).

C4. Payment Posting and Reconciliation

1. ERA and EOB reading; adjustment codes (2 hours).
2. The ERA exception queue and manual posting (2 hours).
3. IDR award payments: matching to the determination within 2 business days; flagging awards unpaid after 30 days (2 hours).
4. Refund flags, claim closure and batch balancing (2 hours).

C5. Medical-Necessity Report and Documentation

1. Reading the ER chart: complaint, acuity, workup, treatment, disposition (2 hours).
2. The approved LLM tool, the current prompt version and PHI rules (2 hours).
3. Fact-checking every statement against the chart (2 hours).
4. Filing to the patient hub within 1 business day; the QA checklist (2 hours).

Course materials for each badge: a trainer guide, slides, a scenario bank, the QA checklist from the QA department, and a ClickUp supervised-production template. The chair approves every update to them.

Advanced badge curriculum

Advanced badges take 54 classroom hours across the four courses and carry stricter reviews, because errors here cost the most. Each team needs at least 2 holders of each badge, so the committee sets cohorts from the team badge grid, not from requests alone.

Badge	Prerequisite	Classroom	Supervised production	Assessment	QA to earn	Usual trainer
A1 Coding (Certified)	CPC, COC or CCS certification; C5	16 hours	200 charts: every one of the first 50 reviewed, then a 20% sample	Blind coding test of 50 charts	95%	L4 A1 holder, with QA
A2 IDR Packet and Offer Strategy	C2 and C5	16 hours	20 batched disputes, 160+ codes	Full packet and written offer rationale for one dispute	97%, plus 98% first-pass tickets	L4 A2 holder
A3 MVA and Adjuster Negotiation	C1 and C3	10 hours	15 settlements	Role-play with the assessor as adjuster; 3 closed files	95%	L4 A3 holder

Badge	Prerequisite	Classroom	Supervised production	Assessment	QA to earn	Usual trainer
A4 Payer Strategy	A2, and L2 or above	12 hours	Co-own one payer playbook with an L4 Senior Specialist II for 1 quarter	Present and defend the playbook to the panel	90% on the scorecard	L4 A4 holder

A1. Coding (Certified)

1. ER professional E/M leveling (99281–99285) and facility levels (4 hours).
2. Procedures, ICD-10 specificity and medical decision-making documentation (4 hours).
3. Modifiers, claim scrubbing, and HCFA and UB-04 preparation for Logistics (4 hours).
4. Current coding guideline updates and the latest audit findings from the coding quality owner (4 hours).

The company pays for the certification exam, renewals and CEUs. Uncertified coders get exam preparation support and a target exam date.

A2. IDR Packet and Offer Strategy

1. The IDR timeline and every Gateway action (2 hours).
2. Batching rules: same payer, same or similar service codes, within the allowed window (2 hours).
3. IDR entity selection and objections (2 hours).
4. Setting offers with the pricing guide and outcome data (3 hours).
5. Writing the packet: answering the QPA and the additional factors (acuity, complexity, good-faith negotiation) (4 hours).
6. US desk tickets, determinations logging and outcome review (3 hours).

Under Model C, the proposed model, add a 2-hour module on preparing disputes in the IDR Prep Studio, the copy desk the US team files from. If Model B is adopted later, add a 4-hour module on building bundles and the Bundle QA checklist.

A3. MVA and Adjuster Negotiation

1. Order of coverage: auto, PIP, MedPay, health and liability (3 hours).
2. Carrier filing limits, liens and attorney correspondence (3 hours).

3. Records release and valid authorization (1 hour).
4. Adjuster negotiation role-plays (3 hours).

A4. Payer Strategy

1. Reading outcome data: QPA patterns, settlements and IDR entity results by payer (3 hours).
2. Building a payer playbook: offer ranges, negotiation behavior, escalation contacts (3 hours).
3. Turning data into recommendations and measuring their effect (3 hours).
4. Presenting to the specialty group and the leadership board (3 hours).

Trainer and assessor certification

Everyone who teaches or assesses completes a 4-hour course on running a module, giving feedback and scoring. Before assessing, each assessor scores 3 sample cases and must agree with the QA reviewer within 5 points. Assessors repeat this calibration every quarter.

Leadership track

Team leads and managers form L5, the Principal (Leadership) level. The growth plan opens about 14 team lead and 7 manager seats, and the Academy prepares internal candidates for them before they are posted.

Course	Who can enrol	Content	Format	Assessment
Team Lead readiness	L3 and above	Coaching and feedback; running the daily huddle and rebalancing work; QA reviews and coaching plans; settlement decision rights and approvals; deadlines and escalation; people policies	6 sessions of 2 hours, plus 4 weeks covering for a team lead	Coaching assessment: an observed 1:1 coaching session and a workload rebalancing case, scored by the chair, a manager and a team lead
Manager readiness	Team leads with 12 months in the role, and L4s	Performance management and scorecards; Net Recovery and reporting; in-house hiring and onboarding; change management; running a portfolio; presenting to the leadership board	8 sessions of 2 hours, plus 1 quarter shadowing a portfolio owner	Presents one monthly portfolio report to the leadership board; panel interview with the director or an assistant director

Completing a course makes a person eligible to apply; it does not guarantee a post. Seats are filled by internal posting first, with the committee shortlisting and the director and assistant directors approving.

Assessment, awarding and promotion

Every badge and promotion follows the same published steps, and every decision is recorded in ClickUp with the evidence behind it.

Earning a badge:

1. **Enrol.** The member enrolls for the next quarterly test window, at least 4 weeks before it opens. New hires and people new to the task are placed in the course first; members who already do the work can test out.
2. **Module.** On the course route, the person attends the classroom hours and passes the end-of-module check, at 80% or higher.
3. **Supervised production.** On the course route, a badge-holder signs off each case in ClickUp until the case count is met.
4. **Assessment.** In the test window (the last two weeks of March, June, September and December), a Badge Panel scores the practical test plus a sample of the supervised cases. The panel is the QA reviewer plus 2 assessors from other teams.
5. **Award.** The chair confirms the badge within 10 business days of the window. Members who tested out complete 10 supervised cases, then ClickUp routing switches on; any allowance starts from the next pay cycle.

When an assessment fails: the panel writes down the gaps. The person practises with their team lead and retakes the test in the next window. A second failure means a new supervised production set, at half the original case count, before another attempt.

Keeping a badge: the semiannual KPI review on June 30 and December 31 decides which badges each member keeps. The June 2027 review is for coaching only, and consequences start in December 2027.

- A badge is lost when, over the half-year, its QA is below the keep threshold, it has 2 or more critical errors, or it was suspended and not re-earned.
- Losing 25% or more of the badges held at the start of the half-year means 90 days of probation and coaching: a written plan, 100% review of the affected work, weekly check-ins and a re-test in the next window.
- Losing 50% or more means termination through the HR process, with one appeal. This rule is subject to HR and legal review before it is published.
- If the badges no longer support the member's level, the level is reset at the next window and pay is protected.
- Between reviews, the monthly rules still apply: one QA review below the keep threshold triggers coaching, and two in a row suspend the badge.

Promotions (quarterly):

1. At quarter end, after the test window, ClickUp lists everyone who meets the badge and performance requirements for the next level.
2. The chair and 2 managers from outside each person's team confirm every case.

3. Promotions take effect on the first day of the next month, with the new portfolio tier and a guaranteed raise starting the same day.
4. Anyone eligible but not promoted gets written reasons and a target quarter.

Appeals: one appeal per decision, filed within 10 business days and heard by committee members who did not make the original decision. The result is final for that quarter.

Rollout and yearly calendar

The Academy is set up before the new teams launch, so that placement in January 2027 runs on published criteria and calibrated assessors.

Wave	When	Who	What	Done when
Set-up	Oct–Nov 2026	Committee	Appoint the chair and members; certify trainers and assessors; publish the curriculum and the 2026 KPI ranking method	Every course has a trainer, materials and calibrated assessors
0 · US desk and tickets	Nov–Dec 2026	US desk, negotiators, bridge night rota volunteers	HIPAA, the IDR Prep Studio copy desk, each Gateway action, escalation; the ticket checklist	Within 15 minutes per dispute and 98% first-pass tickets in the December parallel run
Ranking	Dec 2026	Everyone	Ranking within each current role on 2026 KPIs; top and bottom 10% lists published	Lists checked and published

Wave	When	Who	What	Done when
1 · Transition	Jan–Mar 2027	Everyone	Top 10% receive role badges; bottom 10% join the Academy at L1; the rest take the optional skill assessment and role badge tests in the February or March window	Levels take effect on April 1, 2027
2 · Core skills	Apr–Jun 2027	Anyone missing a core badge	Billers learn C2; negotiators and coders learn C1, C3 and C4; 4 protected hours a week	All 5 core badges by June 30, 2027
3 · Advanced	Jul 2027 on	L2 and above	A1, A2, A3 and A4 cohorts, set from the team badge grid	At least 2 holders of every badge in every team
New hires	Monthly from 2027	Cohorts of 4–6	2-week onboarding, then the L1 path	On track for L2 at 6 months

Committee calendar:

Cadence	What happens	Who
Weekly	30-minute training check: cohorts, supervised production backlog, enrolments for the next window	Chair and trainers
Monthly	New-hire cohort starts on the first Monday; committee meeting; team badge grid published; Academy report sent and presented	Full committee

Cadence	What happens	Who
Quarterly	Test window in the last two weeks of March, June, September and December; promotion panel; assessor calibration; team lead rotation	Chair, manager members, QA reviewer, Badge Panels
Semiannual	KPI review on June 30 and December 31: badges kept or lost, probation plans, termination recommendations	Full committee, with HR for terminations
Yearly	Curriculum review against changes in rules, payers and coding guidelines; committee renewal	Committee, with the director

Academy KPIs and reporting

The chair reports these every month: in writing to the director and assistant directors, and in person at the leadership board meeting, with recommendations for the board to act on.

KPI	Target	Measured
Specialists holding all 5 core badges	100% by June 30, 2027	Monthly
Teams with 2 or more holders of every badge	100%; no gap open for more than 30 days	Monthly
Transition tests completed by March 31, 2027	100% of the middle 80%	Once
New hires reaching L2 within 6 months	80% or more	Per cohort
First-attempt pass rate in test windows	75–90% (higher suggests the test is too easy)	Quarterly
Test-window results published	Within 10 business days	Quarterly
Semiannual review completed and communicated	Within 15 business days of June 30 and December 31	Semiannual
Members on probation who recover	70% or more within 90 days	Semiannual

KPI	Target	Measured
Deadlines missed by newly badged staff	Zero	Monthly
Training hours delivered against plan	95% or more, with protected hours kept	Monthly
Assessor agreement with the QA reviewer	Within 5 points	Quarterly
Promotions decided on time; appeals closed	100% within the window; appeals within 10 business days	Quarterly
Trainee rating of courses	4 out of 5 or higher	Per course

Monthly Academy report:

1. The team badge grid, with gaps and the plan to close them.
2. Cohorts in progress and assessments passed and failed.
3. New-hire progress against the 6-month plan.
4. Quality signals: QA of new holders, suspensions, critical errors.
5. Feedback from the coding quality, denials and IDR performance owners that changes the curriculum.
6. Recommendations and decisions needed from the board.